

Readings

Romans 5: 3b-5

We also boast in tribulations, knowing that tribulation works endurance; and endurance, experience; and experience, hope; and hope does not make ashamed, because the love of God is shed abroad in our hearts by the Holy Spirit which has been given to us:

Romans 8:28

And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love God, who have been called according to God's purpose.

"Pain"

From The Book of Qualities

by J. Ruth Gendler

Pain

Pain is subtle. He has cold gray fingers. His voice is hoarse from crying and screaming. Some people think any time they feel something they don't understand, it is Pain. Other people think feelings themselves are a sign of Pain. When people try to avoid him, he follows them silently and turns up as the bartender or the bus driver or the auctioneer. Pain has an elaborate filing system for keeping track of everyone; he is thinking about asking an old friend of mine to computerize it.

The local university wants to grant Pain tenure, but the students insist his teaching is overrated. The faculty is impressed because when Pain presents his work, it sounds meaningful and difficult.

Pain respects people who are willing to take risks. If you face him directly, he will give you a special ointment so your wounds don't fester.

Buddha

The seed of suffering in you may be strong, but don't wait until you have no more suffering before allowing yourself to be happy.

The Purpose of Pain

It's sort of like mosquitoes. Every spring I find myself ranting about these nasty little bugs that bite, suck our blood, spread diseases, cause unbearable itching and make the worst whining noise when you're trying to sleep. Every year I wonder, "Who thought these would be a good idea?" Then I recall that mosquitoes are an important part of the ecological system. Certain birds, bugs, and bats live on mosquitoes. They feed fish and frogs and pollinate flowers. Their presence influences the flora and fauna of an area. So much of what I enjoy on this planet is supported by these annoying, tiny, blood sucking, monsters. I do not like them! And... without them, my world would be much smaller and duller.

Pain is like that. We don't like it. We wish it would go away and that it didn't even exist. And yet pain is a surprisingly important part of our lives. When we met last, we began this sermon series on pain, paying attention to the ways it is problematic in our lives and in our culture. Today, our series examines the possible benefits of distress, discomfort, and dis-ease.

Pain is complex, with different physical, mental and spiritual sensations and thoughts. The intensity varies and it moves along a continuum. It can start as a little niggling feeling, grow to an annoyance, expand into a genuine hurt, and finally become all consuming.

All this discomfort serves a purpose. Most simply, pain tells us something is wrong. It gets our attention.

It is a great curse to have no distress - even though it sounds as inviting as a world without mosquitoes. Chances are you've heard of Hansen's Disease; it used to be called Leprosy. One symptom of this unfortunate illness is the decreased ability to feel touch and pain. The bacteria of Hansen's isn't what causes the loss of fingers, feet, and limbs. Instead, it silences the signals of harm; the body doesn't feel irritation or trauma. Wounds are not noticed; they get infected, fester, and become inflamed. Eventually those parts of the body can't be

saved and fall off or are amputated. It's the symptom caused by the leprosy bacteria that destroys the body.

Feelings, physical sensations and emotional experiences, give us information. Unpleasant and uncomfortable feelings may tell me I need to make some changes, like take my hand off that hot stove. Or it may tell me that I haven't fully healed from a psychic wound and that I still have work to do.

It's no surprise that discomfort is usually the catalyst for change. The chick in the egg does not hatch out of its shell because it wants to feel the warmth of the sun on its feathers and peck at fresh grubs in the earth. The chick hatches because it is miserable. It has grown so that there is no space left in the shell for its body; it is pressing against all sides of the egg. All the food has been eaten, no more is coming, and the chick is starving. Hatching is hard, messy work. There's lots of pushing and wriggling, pecking and poking. It is not pretty or graceful from the chick's perspective. If the chick wants to live, change is its only option.

When I worked at a drug and alcohol rehabilitation center, there was a poster on one of the case manager's walls. A stick figure, representing a patient, had one hand on its rear end and the other hand waving as if in surrender. The stick person was giving a little jump because a lightning bolt was zapping it on the butt. The caption read "Most people don't see the light until they feel the heat!" So true!

One of the purposes of pain is to provide us information to instigate change.

When the discomfort and distress is social, we are usually learning what society requires of us. Humans are herd animals and our survival depends on our place in the pack. While watching a herd of horses, it was impossible to miss the "teenager" horse who was being a brat to a younger sibling and a general nuisance to the adults of the herd. At one point, one of the older mares had had enough. She put her head down, pinned her ears back, approached the foal, and snaked him out of the herd. Whenever the youngster would try to come back in, the other horses would present their rumps, ready to

kick, and keep the troublemaker out. It's important to understand that for a horse, the herd equals safety and survival. To be out on its own for long becomes a matter of life and death. After a time when the foal demonstrated enough contrition, it was allowed back into the herd, nuzzled up, and reassured. That day, the little foal learned one of the rules about acceptable herd behavior.

Humans do this too. We use words, sideways looks, shunning or shame. There are a million subtle ways humans teach each other what is acceptable. All those unsettling social feelings eventually lead to human cooperation and mutual aid. It happens on a small scale when the neighborhood kids learn to play together and it happens on a global scale when Russia invades Ukraine.

Social discipline is different from punishment. Punishment is the imposition of a penalty in response to an offense. It is hardship added on top of the normal consequences of an action. The people of a town may quit spending time with a person and no longer invite them into their homes if they believe the individual is a thief. That is a reasonable consequence. Cutting off the person's right hand for stealing is punishment.

Social consequences are also different than oppression and torture. Today's sermon is examining some of the purposes of pain. Oppression and torture are about power and control. Subtle or severe, intentional or unconscious - inflicting pain and dehumanizing others belongs in a sermon about evil.

Turning back to social dis-ease, another positive aspect of discomfort is that it is a terrific motivation for learning! When I began training ministers to be chaplains, I naively believed that students engaged with education because it is fun! I love learning new things!

Later, as I learned about teaching, I discovered that students became heavily invested in their education when it could prevent pain. After spending some time on the hospital floors, these chaplaincy students began to see many of the ways they could mess up. They were much more engaged in listening to what elder chaplains had to say, especially when these suggestions could prevent them from going out on the hospital floors and making - more than awkward -

mistakes. There is a delicate balance. Too much distress can make a student paralyzed. Too little, and there is little incentive to learn.

Pain changes people. When some misadventure comes upon a person, they no longer have the time, energy, money, and capacity to manage everything they did before. There is an examination and reshuffling of priorities. As a hospice chaplain, I often hear people claim that despite the many discomforts and constraints, their last year is the best year of their lives. People have permission to use their pain, not to hide from it, and it gives them the freedom to live with more intentionality and integrity.

People who have been through real pain and metabolized it often exhibit a particular strength. Hardship can give people credibility. They have discovered that they are tougher than they thought. Smarter than they expected. I'm reminded that the seeds of the giant sequoia trees stay tucked in their pine cones until fire forces them to open. The seeds must go through the fire before they can claim their place in the forest.

It is said that there are 3 things that change people the most: travel, education, and the last is a crisis. Travel opens our eyes to new ways of experiencing life and makes it plain that the world does not revolve around us. Education challenges our beliefs and opinions. We are stretched and forged and ideally become a better version of ourselves.

The crises that impact us so deeply are usually not so pleasant as travel and education. Think about the turning points in your own life. Perhaps it was something sweet, like falling in love or the birth of a child. Chances are that your crossroads involved loss, disappointment, and death. Events that go hard against us, often surprise us down the road. What had been bad at the time, perhaps unbearable, has led us to a better and un-imagined space.

It is true, we learn from our trials and tribulations more than we learn from our easy wins and smooth successes. However, please don't take this as proof that "Pain is a great teacher," and "Tough times build character." As we explored this aspect of pain in my last sermon,

we don't really learn from harsh experience until we integrate it. Wounds that still ache are not the sources of strength. This is a process and sometimes it may take years.

We metabolize our travail when we are able to process it and give it meaning. Distress that is just random garbage that lands on everyone's lawn is harder to process than angst that has some purpose for us. Part of healing from pain is determining its reason. Think of how often we have heard that the parents of murdered children have started a scholarship or supported a change in the law so that their dear one did not die in vain.

Victor Frankl's famous book, "Man's Search For Meaning" discusses the importance of finding, discovering or creating a reason for one's pain. Frankl refers several times to the words of Nietzsche: "He who has a *why* to live for can bear almost any *how*."

This need to learn the purpose of painful events is so vital, and so dangerous. Frankl wrote that the men in his concentration camp that could find no meaning had no reason to go on living. They usually died an early death. Finding some meaning for our pain is as important as breathing.

Once we come upon a reason, we can endure. If there seems to be no reason, we begin to think "Why bother?"

As comforting as finding a reason can be, the tendency to run to an answer in order to soothe our distress can make a bad situation worse. One example is our culture's insistence that a patient who survived cancer come to a great insight following their ordeal. They are asked "What did you learn? Where was the silver lining in your cloud?" People often voice their disapproval when a cancer survivor does not tie up the whole experience with a neat bow.

Not everyone who lives through the disease has an epiphany. Or if they do, it may be many years coming. Implying that the patient has not overcome successfully because we want a happy ending is selfish and short-sighted.

A similar experience is interpreting another person's pain in order for us to have some closure is just unfair. Let me share a personal

example. During 2010, while I was the chaplain manager of a busy hospital in the northern Twin Cities area , I was in a severe motorcycle crash. It took about a year and a half for me to heal physically. It took another two years before I could address my spiritual pain. This accident deeply disturbed many of the hospital staff. It was confusing and upsetting for them that the chaplain manager, the pastor, of the hospital, had been in such a horrible accident. If God could let this happen to the chaplain, a person who had dedicated her life to God, what would it mean for the average Jane and average Joe? My motorcycle calamity threw their theological world into a tail-spin.

I cannot tell you the number of hospital staff who came to me fairly early in my recovery to explain to me why God had allowed this to happen. Fortunately I understood their need to give the crash some meaning immediately. Still, it often hurt. The reason I heard most was that God allowed this motorcycle crash so that I could learn compassion. Wow - I don't think any of them ever recognized what a huge insult it was to suggest their chaplain didn't have much compassion!

It is true that going through hard stuff can bring about some backward blessings. People learn to be more careful and stop to think before they open their mouths to speak. Difficult experiences can bring people closer to the Divine. (They can also push away bad theology and traditions that make a hard situation worse.)

Connections are made with others who have been in similar experiences and there is more appreciation for their caregivers. The very fact that we are still living can inspire more awe after a profound experience with pain. We may feel more gratitude. Some people, after going through a profoundly harsh experience, believe that they are called to help carry the cosmic pain of the world and the universe. Instead of avoiding discomfort, they step in to help shoulder the burden for all beings. Our pain may expand our compassion, help us extend more forgiveness to ourselves and others, and insist we lean into courage we did not know we possessed.

During these times of misfortune, pain can give us something to push against. Struggling for change is hard enough. Distress can, at times, be a solid thing that gives us a focal point. For example, people who report on their physical therapy often share that they make more progress when they are dealing with some discomfort. If they aren't hurting, it is hard to convince themselves they need to do the exercises. The affliction goads them on.

To celebrate turning 50, I drove race cars for a day. In some cars, there is an extra foot pedal on the floor; it is on the far left side of the driver's side. It doesn't do anything, like make the car go faster or corner better. The only thing it is for is to give the driver something to push against when they need to use their whole body to maneuver the vehicle. A driver doesn't need this phony pedal, yet it makes all the difference in bringing the car the shortest route through the turns. Just something to push against.

In a shared catastrophe, such as during a natural or human made disaster, a community usually goes through four phases. In the first week or two, heroes arise, common people who step up unbidden to do extraordinary things. These are the stories that are played over and over in the news. Witnessing all the heroes leads into a honeymoon phase. The community bands together, reassuring one another, appreciating the strength and skills of each other and committing to working together to rebuild their homes and businesses.

Next comes a period of disillusionment. People begin looking for someone to blame. Rumors leak out about departments and individuals who let everybody down. People are upset that neither the leadership nor the followers are doing such a swell job. This becomes a negative feeding frenzy for the media and politicians. The energy of the honeymoon has faded and people start to realize how much work lies ahead. Finally, after the disillusionment, the blood, sweat and tears of restoration begins, and may continue for years. If you pay attention to news cycles, you will witness these phases play out again and again in large and small scale emergencies.

We've been focusing on what can be gained through sorrow and distress. Pain can also lead to letting go. Chances are that you know someone who has bravely kept up the fight - continuing to battle cancer, staying in a maddening relationship for the kids, going to work every morning when the treatment is a daily exercise in humiliation. In the course of angst and pain, there comes a time when a person is willing to let go. The patient whose whole identity has become the person fighting cancer, finally decides it is time to quit. That identity no longer holds. It is particularly hard for family and friends to watch this surrender. They might not be ready to let go; they may want them to keep up the good fight.

It is also true that after witnessing a loved one's pain for so long, people come to a place where they are also ready to let go. To lose them can't feel as bad as watching them suffer.

After extended or intense hard times, people loosen their grip on life and on each other. What began as a problem evolved into an agony. Pain allows us to let go. It allows people to leave relationships with compassion and jobs with dignity. It grants people the opportunity to die peacefully. Pain changes from a horror to a gift.

Pain points to a need for change, and change is hard. Try telling the hatching chick that their world falling apart is really no big deal. Pain and change can lead to transformation. Chances are you've heard the story of the ugly caterpillar turning into the beautiful butterfly. This report from nature is used to give people hope and encouragement that their misfortune can turn into something good, perhaps even something amazing.

And it is true. All of us could tell personal or anecdotal stories of an unlikely difficulty transforming into a blessing.

It's too bad that when the butterfly story is shared, one of the most important components is left out. It is almost never mentioned that while the caterpillar waits in the chrysalis, it is not gently resting, biding its time to glory. The caterpillar loses itself to become a mass of pulp held inside the chrysalis. Slowly, after it has been completely taken apart, it is reconstructed into something new and lovely.

It's a tougher tale, unpleasant to think about, yet much more realistic. Given what most people experience around profound pain, it would be a kindness to acknowledge that the caterpillar goes all to pieces before putting itself back together in a new form. It would be helpful for people in crisis to hear that the lovely butterfly is completely undone for a time. It points to the absolute hope that pain may have a positive purpose after all.

When we meet again, this sermon series on pain will dive into the muddled waters of pain, faith, and religion. Until that time, hold your pain gently, or use it as something to push against. Watch for the unexpected ways distress can offer goodness, in the present moment of angst and in the future hope for something better. Care for yourselves and each other honestly, without forcing meaning on your difficulties. If you find yourself like the chick pressed about on all sides with no expectation of nourishment or space, begin to chip away at your confinement with the desperate hope that there is a new world on the other side.

And if you find yourself like the caterpillar, turned to pulp in the chrysalis, wait, and slowly put yourself together, molecule by molecule.

Amen and Amen.